

Instructor Guide — Lesson 5: Create Your Personal Brand

Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path → Course 16: Build Your Professional Identity → Lesson 5
- **Lesson title:** Create Your Personal Brand
- **Audience:** Ages 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led, virtual classroom
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tools used:** Canva, Google Docs (bio/case study from Lesson 4), HTML/CSS portfolio site (from Lesson 3), GitHub, Vercel
- **Prerequisites:** L2 (direction/niche statement), L3 (portfolio site skeleton live on Vercel), L4 (bio + first case study draft)
- **Lesson outcome:** Each student leaves with a one-page "Brand Kit" (2–3 colors with hex codes, one font pairing, a simple monogram/mark concept, and a one-line brand voice descriptor) that they can apply to their existing portfolio site.

Prep (before class)

- [] Open Canva and have a blank design ready to share-screen (1080×1080 or a simple "Brand Board" template).
- [] Prepare **one full example brand kit** in Canva ahead of time for a fictional student ("Jordan R.," a student interested in game design) — palette swatches with hex codes, font pairing sample text, and a simple monogram (e.g., a circle with "JR" in a bold geometric font). This is your live-demo reference and fallback if live building runs long.
- [] Have a WCAG contrast checker bookmarked (e.g., WebAIM Contrast Checker) to demonstrate the accessibility check live.
- [] Pull up 2–3 students' actual portfolio sites from L3 to reference during discussion (with permission / already shared in class).
- [] Have the Student Lesson and Worksheet links ready to drop in chat.
- [] Review each student's L4 bio for tone — you'll reference it when discussing "voice."

Teaching Sequence

1. Hook + Reframe (5 min)

Open by asking: "What's a brand you recognize instantly, even with no words or logo visible — just a color or a shape?" Take 2–3 quick answers in chat (e.g., a red-and-white color combo, a golden arch, a specific font). Land the point: **recognition came from repetition of simple visual choices, not from a complicated logo.**

Talking point (say this directly): "A brand is not a logo. A brand is the *consistent set of choices* — colors, fonts, words, and tone — that make people recognize you and remember what you're about, even across different pages or posts. Today you're not designing a logo like a professional graphic designer would. You're picking 3–4 simple, repeatable choices and using them everywhere."

2. Direct Instruction: The Four Brand Elements (10 min)

Walk through each element on screen, using Jordan R.'s example kit to illustrate:

1. **Color palette (2–3 colors)** — one dominant, one accent, optionally one neutral (white/black/gray).
2. **Font pairing (2 fonts max)** — one for headings, one for body text. They should look different enough to create contrast but not clash.
3. **A simple mark** — initials in a shape, an icon that relates to their niche, or just their name set in their heading font at a consistent size/color. This is NOT a logo design exercise — one shape, one or two colors, done in Canva in under 10 minutes.
4. **Tone of voice** — 3 adjectives that describe how they want to sound in writing (e.g., "curious, precise, friendly"). Point back to their L4 bio and ask: does the bio's wording match these adjectives?

Accessibility talking point: "Whatever colors you pick, your body text needs to stay easy to read. If you put light gray text on a white background, most people — including people with low vision — will struggle to read it. We're going to check contrast live in a second."

3. Live Demo: Building Jordan R.'s Brand Kit in Canva (15 min)

Share screen and build live (or narrate your pre-built kit step by step, editing one piece live to show process):

1. Open a blank Canva design. Add three rectangles as color swatches. Use Canva's color picker to enter hex codes directly (e.g., **#1B3A4B** deep navy, **#F2A93B** warm amber, **#F5F5F0** off-white). Label each swatch with its hex code and where it's used ("navy = header/nav bar," "amber = buttons/links," "off-white = background").
2. Open the WCAG contrast checker in another tab. Test navy text on off-white background — show it passes. Test amber text on white — show it's borderline/fails for small body text, and explain: "This is why amber is for buttons and accents, not paragraph text."
3. Add font pairing: pick one bold/geometric heading font and one clean, readable body font from Canva's font list. Type a sample heading and a sample sentence to show them side by side.
4. Build the simple mark: a circle or hexagon in the dominant color, with "JR" in the heading font, in white or the accent color, centered inside.
5. Add the tone-of-voice line: "curious, precise, encouraging."
6. Step back and show the whole board together — point out that every piece reinforces the same 2–3 colors and 2 fonts.

4. Guided Practice (20 min)

Students open their own Canva and build their own Brand Kit board using the Worksheet as their checklist. Instructor circulates in breakout/monitoring, checking in on:

- Are the two accent colors distinct enough to tell apart, but not clashing?
- Is body text contrast passing (spot-check with the contrast tool if a student flags a light color)?
- Is the mark simple — one shape, one or two colors, legible at small size?
- Does the tone-of-voice line match what's actually in their L4 bio?

5. Discussion + Share-Out (7 min)

Ask 2–3 volunteers to share their screen for 60 seconds each. Prompt the class with:

- "What's one word you'd use to describe [student]'s brand just from the colors and font, before reading anything?"
- "Where do you think this color palette would look good on your portfolio site — header, buttons, background?"

6. Lesson Close (3 min)

Recap: "You now have a brand kit — a small, repeatable set of choices. Next lesson, you'll apply these exact colors and fonts to your live portfolio site's CSS so it looks like one consistent thing, not three different websites stitched together." Assign submission: export/share the Canva board link and fill out the Worksheet, submit both per class instructions.

Discussion Questions

- Why might "more colors" or "more fonts" actually make a brand feel less professional, not more?
- Think of a brand that changed its look over time but you still recognized it — what stayed the same?
- How does your tone-of-voice descriptor need to show up in your bio's actual wording, not just as an idea?

Common Misconceptions

- **"I need a fancy/professional logo."** No — a simple monogram or consistent name treatment is enough at this stage. Professional logo design is a specialized skill; today's goal is consistency, not artistry.
- **"Brand = logo."** Reinforce: brand is the whole system (color + font + voice + consistency). A logo is just one small piece, and some strong brands don't even have one, just consistent color/type.
- **"More colors = more exciting."** Too many colors reads as chaotic and unfinished. Constraint (2–3 colors) is what makes it look intentional.
- **"My tone of voice can be whatever sounds cool."** It needs to match how they actually write in their bio and case study, or the brand feels fake.

Common Student Difficulties

- **Picking colors with poor contrast** — light-on-light or bright-on-bright combos that fail readability. Fix live with the contrast checker; suggest darkening or using the light color only as a small accent.
- **Choosing two fonts that are too similar** (e.g., two thin sans-serifs) so the pairing has no visual contrast, or two fonts that clash in mood (a playful script with a harsh technical mono). Suggest one clearly different pairing: a bold/geometric heading font + a simple readable body font.
- **Overcomplicating the mark** — trying to draw a detailed logo. Redirect to initials-in-a-shape or their name in their heading font as the simplest valid option.
- **Vague tone-of-voice adjectives** ("nice," "good," "cool") that don't say anything specific. Push for adjectives that differentiate them, referencing their L2 niche and L4 bio wording.

Troubleshooting

- **Canva running slowly / student can't access:** Have them use Canva's free plan template gallery search "brand board" as a faster starting point, or build the kit as a simple table in Google Docs (colors + hex + fonts named + mark described in words) if Canva is inaccessible.
- **Student has no niche direction from L2:** Briefly help them pick one adjacent interest to anchor color/tone choices for today; flag for follow-up outside class.
- **Contrast checker site blocked on school network:** Use the visual rule of thumb instead — dark text needs a light background and vice versa; avoid pairing two "medium brightness" colors for text/background.

How to Review

When checking submitted Brand Kits, confirm: 1. Exactly 2–3 colors, each with a hex code and a stated use. 2. One font pairing (heading + body), visually distinct. 3. A simple, legible mark (not overworked, not missing). 4. A three-adjective voice descriptor that's specific, not generic. 5. Body text color/background combo would plausibly pass a basic contrast check.

Leave one specific piece of praise and one specific suggestion per student (e.g., "Your navy/amber pair is great — consider making amber only a small accent since it's harder to read at small sizes").

Lesson Close Script

"Today you didn't design a logo — you built a small system of choices you'll now use everywhere: your portfolio, your bio, future posts. Consistency is what makes people remember you. Bring your Brand Kit link to the next lesson — we're applying it directly to your live site's CSS."